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MULTIPLE LITERACIES AND LANGUAGE COMPETENCIES ACROSS YOUNG CHILDREN'S SOCIAL CONTEXTS

Ways with printed words . . . are always integrally and inextricably integrated with ways of talking, thinking, believing, knowing, acting, interacting, valuing, and feeling. We cannot just take the “print bits” out and forget the rest. (Gee 2002, 30)

Young Children's Meaning Making Across Contexts

“Da-da-da,” Logan points to his father. “Da-da-dá,” Ana points to crackers. Children make meaning and make sense in a variety of contexts. In Logan's home in Brooklyn, New York, “Da-da-da” signifies dad. In Ana's home in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, “Da-da-dá” signifies give me (and as she points to crackers, *dá*, from the Portuguese verb *dar*, comes to signify “give me”). Children's communicative repertoires are contextual, as illustrated by these two infants' communicative practices. Utterances gain meaning in social contexts, communicating very different intentions across cultural communities. As Bakhtin (1981, 262–263) pinpoints, there is “a diversity of social speech types (sometimes even diversity of languages) and a diversity of individual voices” and “languages that serve the specific sociopolitical purposes of the day, even of the hour.” Therefore, the words we choose, the contexts in which we say those words, and the community of people we utter the words to are purposeful and experiential.

Young children are exposed to language in various contexts before entering school—homes, communities, peers, and the environment. They start reading their environment and authoring themselves in the world. For example, in New York City, young children may read Figure 3.1 as “subway,” whereas

children (and even adults) who grew up in other locales, may have difficulty identifying a subway station. Yet, the green iron structures on the city’s sidewalks are easily identified by children growing up in New York City—they read them as signifying subway.

Even the word subway varies across contexts within the same community. For example, in New York, subway may be used to signify a train or a sandwich (Figure 3.2). After all, “each word tastes of the context and contexts in which it has lived its socially charged life; all words and forms are populated by intentions” (Bakhtin 1981, 293).

In addition to language varying across larger contexts, it also varies across communities and within communities across interlocutors. For instance, it is very likely that we communicate differently with someone interviewing us for a professional position compared to a significant other. Similar to adults, young children deploy distinct communicative practices when playing with peers and communicating with a parent or teacher. Within contexts, they may engage in language variation as they take on different roles in play or when they are



FIGURE 3.1 Subway Station

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FIGURE 3.2 Subway: Sandwich or Train?

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creating storylines with dolls who signify differing roles (for example, mother and daughter). Wolfram, Adger, and Christian (1999, 1) label such variation dialect, “a variety of a language associated with a regionally or socially defined group of people.” In such a vein, we can understand that the so-called “Standard English [and any ‘standard’ language] . . . is a collection of the socially preferred dialects from various parts of the United States and other English-speaking countries” (Wolfram, Adger, and Christian 1999, 17). Yet, specific communicative practices and dialects are valued differently within and across communities and communicative contexts in society. With this recognition, Adger, Wolfram, and Christian (2007, 1) posited: “Every language differs to some degree from place to place and from group to group.”

They use the term *language variation* to refer to the fact that a language is not uniform. Instead, it varies according to social characteristics of groups of people, such as their cultural background, geographical location, social class, gender, or age. Language variation may also refer to differences in the way that language is used in different settings, such as in the home, the community, and the school, and on different occasions, such as telling a friend about a trip or planning a trip with a travel agent. (Adger, Wolfram, and Christian 2007, 1)

Adger, Wolfram, and Christian go on to explain that “groups that contrast linguistically and culturally with mainstream society have been identified [according to]: the deficit position and the difference position” (2007, 17). Many—in (pre)schools and in society—still believe that language variation is an ailment and “speakers of dialects with vernacular forms have a handicap—socially and cognitively” (Adger, Wolfram, and Christian 2007, 17). Members of dominant groups in society “often believe that members of the stigmatized groups must change in order to be accepted” (Adger, Wolfram, and Christian 2007, 17). We strongly disagree with this perspective. To be sure, the language of power is not semantically or syntactically superior; it is the language of those who have power (Delpit 1988). Although (over)valued in society, it is not always the most appropriate way of communicating. Seeking to trouble existing language hierarchies, here we use the term *language variation* instead of dialect to underscore that linguistic and communicative differences do not comprise deficits. Adger, Wolfram, and Christian reaffirm that “no variety of a language is inherently better than another in terms of how languages are organized. No speakers have a diminished ability to function cognitively and expressively as a result of the variety of the language that they acquire” (2007, 17).

Young children’s language usage is purposeful; their communicative repertoires serve as tools to engage with others in their immediate contexts—to interact with adults, to connect with other children, and to participate in sociocultural activities. They learn language to communicate. They speak because it serves a purpose. They do not learn about language; they learn through language. They draw on their language universe to make meaning—navigating within and across boundaries established by adults, some of which we call languages. They make use of their entire communicative repertoires to make meaning—drawing from what adults often see as different languages, such as English and Spanish. As Genishi and Dyson (1984, 1) remind us: “At a time of life when we credit them with little intelligence, children master a most complex and sophisticated system of sounds and meanings.” In making meaning, young children establish identities through active participation in their social and cultural communities using language as a mediating tool.

Literacy as Reading the Word and the World

Literacy is much broader than reading and writing symbols; it includes reading words and worlds (Freire and Macedo 1987). The movement from world to word is always present. Yet, context and prior experiences re-presented in classroom materials (books, posters) and curricula tend to advantage those who are members of and fluent in the culture of power (Delpit 1988). It is from such a perspective that in this chapter we explore the social, cultural, and political contexts that influence children’s language interactions, and move toward critically redefining what it means to be “literate.” Through a variety of examples, we explain

how being literate in one social context, especially in the digital, contemporary age, does not always translate into “literate” in another context (Marsh 2005a, 2005b). Print literacy is just one mode of literacy, often (over)valued and largely communicated in the context of school. However, children come to school with the “communicative and linguistic practices of their cultural communities, popular culture [practices] in conjunction with media and peers, and the cultural norms that validate and make available specific resources for multimodal production” (Yoon 2016, 4). Thus, their literacy practices are not restricted to print.

Literacy: Challenging Adult Definitions, Honoring the Brilliance of Young Children

Children learn the rules of their language through communicating, before ever entering school or having a formal lesson. “By the time they start kindergarten, children know most of the fundamentals of their language, so that they are able to converse easily with someone who speaks as they do (that is, in their dialect)” (Genishi 1988, 2). Yet they are often seen through deficit lenses, measured against adult definitions of language and literacy (which are often very restrictive). They are regarded as not knowing much, needing literacy, and not being “ready” (Graue 1992).

Bakhtin (1981, 259) reminded us that:

The study of verbal art can and must overcome the divorce between an abstract “formal” approach and an equally abstract “ideological” approach. Form and content in discourse are one, once we understand that verbal discourse is a social phenomenon—social throughout its entire range and in each and every of its factors, from the sound image to the furthest reaches of abstract meaning.

For example, in Figure 3.3, a three-year-old child engaged in a written conversation, clearly attending to the way print looks. He used a number of wiggly lines to signify “chicken.” Through the process of authoring multiple wiggly lines, he demonstrated his knowledge that in English, print is read from left to right, top to bottom. These are part of what Marie Clay (1993, 2000) titled *Concepts About Print*. This three-year-old child showed in this written conversation that he knew much about how written language works.

Genishi (1988, 2) explains that human beings are born to communicate; “they have an innate gift for figuring out the rules of the language used in their environment.” They become literate within a certain context. The context is a very important factor. Children learn language through interactions with those around them. Yet, they may display their learnings in ways that don’t signify much to us adults. For example, learning about animal behavior from firsthand observation,



FIGURE 3.3 Hello. What is Your Favorite Food? Chicken.

(pre)schooler Travyon sketched notes comprised of symbolic representations (Figure 3.4). Although these notes did not make sense to adults and did not make sense to him after a few hours had elapsed, they are part of the process of his development as a writer. He understands that print (written language) serves specific purposes; he used written symbols to make meaning. He shows us how writing letters is not necessarily a precursor to written communication.

As Owocki and Goodman (2002, 81) explained, although Travyon had not “yet discovered conventional letter forms,” he was “attending to the way print looks.” They proposed:

Although children’s early forms of cursive and print aren’t readable to adults, and aren’t even readable to the writers soon after they’ve written, we call this writing because it is intended to communicate meaning . . . [through] circles, squiggles, lines, crosses, and letterlike forms. (Owocki and Goodman 2002, 81–82)

In addition to observing and participating in particular contexts, children engage in figuring out and testing language and literacy rules. They read from signs and pictures. They may associate the McDonald’s golden arches with french fries based on their prior experiences. They may repeat what adults say. But beyond that, they figure out the rules and variations within their home language(s). For example, children may repeat “I went high” when recounting their adventure on



FIGURE 3.4 Making Meaning Through Symbols

the playground's swing or author their own: "I go high" or "I goed high," experimenting with syntactic rules by initially engaging in the overuse of generalized conventions in one or more languages, using the conventions of one language in another (for example, using *y* in Spanish to connect sentences in English), and eventually becoming strategic language users and code-switchers employing the syntactic rules governing a specific language and abiding to adult expectations of language use.

In her TED talk, Kuhl (2010) declares that babies are linguistic geniuses. That is, they have infinite capacity to learn languages—and to produce sounds that adults later become unable to muster. Based on brain research, she affirms that: "Babies and children are geniuses until they turn seven, and then there's a systematic decline." She goes on to declare that infants are "citizens of the world." Differently from adults, who have difficulty hearing specific sounds (for example, it is not uncommon for native Spanish speakers to have difficulty with

tonal languages and for native Japanese speakers to differentiate between the /r/ and /l/ sounds), most hearing babies “can discriminate all the sounds of all languages, no matter what country we’re testing and what language we’re using, and that’s remarkable because you and I can’t do that. We’re culture-bound listeners. We can discriminate the sounds of our own language, but not those of foreign languages.” She urges us to recognize the genius in every infant; after all, their small brains can undertake complex processes often absent in adults. While we do not fully agree with the deterministic and linear nature of the process described by Kuhl and do not subscribe to the idea of fixed “critical periods,” as we recognize that children move along unique timelines for learning and growth, we learn from her work about the infinite linguistic capacity of infants, even while reaffirming our opposition to lockstep, linear, and uniform learning processes.

Language acquisition is a sophisticated and complex process. Throughout time, the field has moved from the understanding put forth by B. F. Skinner in *Verbal Behavior* (1957), which posited that language acquisition is similar to the acquisition of other observable behaviors with an emphasis on “the importance of the environment, rather than a person’s thought processes in shaping learning,” and purported that “people learn largely through responding to stimuli” (Genishi and Dyson 1984, 5). Then, with Noam Chomsky’s 1959 critique of Skinner, which rated Skinner’s theory to be at once simplistic and empty, there was a call for the study of the formal properties of a grammar to learn how “human beings are specially designed” (p. 57) to learn language. Chomsky (1957) proposed that human beings have a “built-in structure,” which accounts for our ability to mean, to communicate, to author words and sentences in a short amount of time despite relatively impoverished linguistic input. Not too long after Chomsky’s theory of *universal grammar*, developmentalists critiqued his theory for not taking development into account. It was then that Piaget and Inhelder (1969) proposed that children’s language develops as they interact with their environment. Later, scholars attempted to explain how children acquire language from a constructivist approach (Genishi and Dyson 1984; Olah 2000) proposing that children learn language through interactions with the people and places where they belong. Since then, scholars sought to understand how complex the process of language acquisition is—exploring pragmatic factors and cross-linguistic differences, for example. This complexity has been called “cumulative complexity,” to refer to the process whereby as “children’s utterances increase in length, the rules they must unconsciously know to form them increase in both number and difficulty” (Genishi and Dyson 1984, 5). That is, their use of language and “what they can do with language becomes more complex” (pp. 5–6), going beyond the complexity of sentences to encompass complexity of communication (bringing together multiple ideas, for example).

From such understandings, a constructivist or interactive approach to language development emerged, positioning children as active participants in their own

language acquisition and learning, with a sociolinguistic focus on context. This is predicated on the tenet that “the social situation can have powerful effects on the kind of language a child produces. To learn how children use language we need to see them in a variety of contexts, using a range of sociolinguistic abilities” (Genishi and Dyson 1984, 2–3), and not only within the context of laboratories, which have punctuated studies in early childhood throughout time (such as Bronfenbrenner’s).

Through a comparative study of literacy practices, Heath (1982, 49) underscored “the inadequacy of unilinear models of child language development and dichotomies between types of cognitive styles.” Further, she called on researchers to study and seek to understand “the development of language use in relation to written materials in home and community” employing “a broad framework of sociocultural analysis” (Heath 1982, 49). From a sociocultural theoretical perspective, literacies and literacy practices are complex, interactive, and interpretative actions located in specific social and cultural realms.

As educators, we have long paid attention to the social context in which children learn and develop. But, to many, the phrase “social context” may suggest no more than the societal setting in which events occur—in this case, the various surroundings at home, at school, and in the community in which children learn to talk, read and write. In recent years, however, a much more radical understanding of the importance of the social context of development has emerged as the result of a convergence of theoretical and empirical research in a variety of disciplines. According to this new understanding of social context, human infants are not only influenced by the social context in which they develop, but their very development as humans is dependent on opportunities to participate with others, notably parents, family members, peers and teachers, in the activities that constitute the culture in which they are growing up. Children’s development is thus as much a social as an individual achievement. (Wells 2009, 271)

That is, through interactions in sociocultural contexts, children learn by communicating with others. This is the approach we employ here. Yet, we move beyond such a constructivist approach, in positioning young children agentively, not only acquiring language, but also (re)writing and (re)authoring interactions and contexts (as exemplified in Chapter 1). A relational literacies approach “compels a consideration of agency as an always contingent and contextualized relational practice as well as a possibility for action” (Licona and Chávez 2015, 98).

Children develop print awareness as they play with language through materials and resources (e.g., puppets), authoring imaginary worlds. Through engagement in pretend play (Genishi and Dyson 2009), children test out hypotheses about language and try on different voices and interactional sequences. They understand “how language is used in particular social contexts, or . . . how social structure

is related to linguistic structure” (Genishi and Dyson 1984, 7). In doing so, they develop and enact rich and diverse communicative repertoires.

In Phillip Baumgarten’s Head Start classroom in Georgia, U.S., children use print to make meaning (attending to the way that print looks). The room is filled with food packages, catalogs, restaurant menus, receipts, phone books, coupons, maps, pads of paper, Post-its, and other materials, which allow children to authentically engage with print in culturally relevant and contextually situated ways. Through “familiar literacy events,” such as “bedtime stories, reading cereal boxes, stop signs, and television ads, and interpreting instructions for commercial games and toys,” children learn to “follow socially established rules for verbalizing what they know from and about the written material” (Heath 1982, 50). These artifacts gain meaning as children engage in repurposing and remixing them.

For example, after noticing that his friend Asia was not feeling well, Jameel held her hand, walked her to the reading area, and told her: “You sit here, I’m take care of you.” He grabbed a marker and brushed it across her forehead. “You real hot, girl. I’m write some medicine for you to feel good.” Then, he grabbed an orange crayon and a small notepad and proceeded to write down wiggly lines

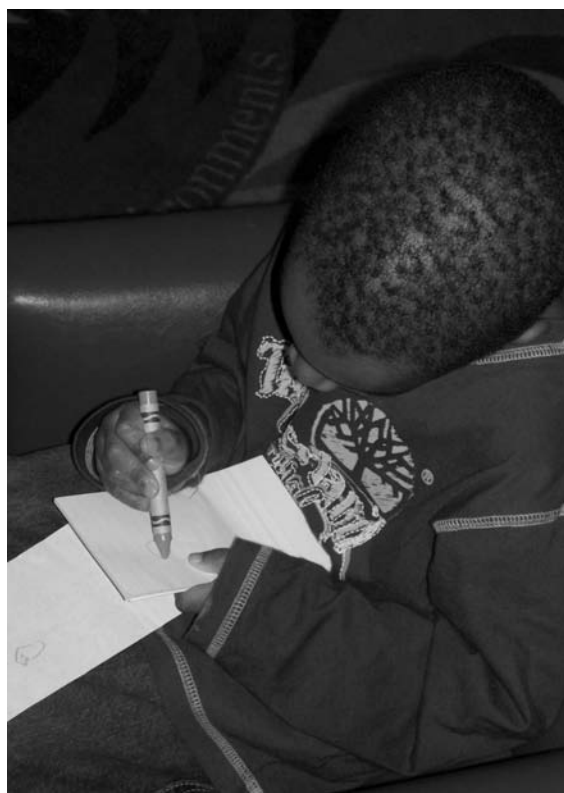


FIGURE 3.5 Writing with Purpose

(Figure 3.5), as he voiced: “You gotta take two of them. You’s gonna be better.” Asia, who was looking at the floor the entire time, head hanging, peered at Jameel and smiled. At the bottom of his prescription, he made a very big and dark marking. Looking up at Asia, he declared: “My signature. So they know iz legit. So they give you the medicines.” Within the social context of play, Jameel was engaging in a familiar literacy event. He attended to the way written and oral language were used within the social context of a medical doctor’s office. He appropriated literacies and enacted specific practices and identities through play.

On the Purpose of Literacy

As young children negotiate literate identities, their purpose is to communicate and interact with other human beings (Wells 1986). Regardless of how print looks (or whether words are spelled conventionally), children advance their understandings and practices of weaving symbols through practice with the intent of communicating. M. A. K. Halliday (1973, 1975), referring specifically to oral language, and more interested in communicative functions than in word acquisition, proposes that children have difficulty learning to read because of the way(s) reading is taught and the materials employed. That is, reading “bear[s] little resemblance to what the child has learned about the function of oral language” (Taylor and Vawter 1978, 943).

Halliday (1975) identified seven different functions of oral language:

- **Instrumental:** When language is used to communicate preferences, choices, wants, or needs (“Give me a . . .”). Often employed in classrooms for problem solving, gathering materials, role playing, and persuading.
- **Personal:** When language is used to express individuality (“I am . . .”). Employed by young children as they engage in making their feelings public and negotiate interactions with others.
- **Interactional:** When language is used to interact and plan, develop, or maintain a play, group activity, or social relationship (“I’ll be the mom, you’ll be . . .”). Seen in classrooms where children engage in play, dialogue, and discussions, and talking in groups.
- **Regulatory:** When language is used to control (“You need to do . . .”). This function of language comes into play as children engage in making rules for games and play and explaining how to do something.
- **Representational:** When language is used to explain (“I’ll tell you what my momma said . . .”). Young children engage with the representational function of language when they convey messages, share something about the real world, or express a proposition.
- **Heuristic:** When language is used to find things out, wonder, or hypothesize (“What if?” and “Why?”). Young children engage with the heuristic function of language when they answer questions, engage in inquiry and research.

- **Imaginative:** When language is used to create, explore, and entertain (“Let’s just pretend that . . .” or “Last night, my bed turned into chocolate . . .”). Young children engage the imaginative function of language when they act out stories, play with rhymes, and engage in other kinds of word play.

It is important to make room in the classroom for children to explore the multiple functions of oral language. After all, these oral language functions shed light onto written language. As Halliday stated, children learn an oral language because it serves a function: to communicate! A parallel can be made here to reading and writing—to written language more broadly.

As James Gee (2002, 31) explained:

Sociocultural practices that embed “ways with printed words” almost always involve human beings both coordinating and getting coordinated by other people, as well as other forms of language, nonverbal images and symbols, objects, tools, technologies, sites and times. . . . Such practices are a “dance” in which people are simultaneously active (coordinating) and passive (getting coordinated), a dance in which they get “in synch” with other people.

For example, in the birthday card below (Figure 3.6), a five-year-old child in Pre-K, Nico, wrote a birthday message for his teacher. Although for those outside of education, this may simply seem to be a note, Nico’s actions tell us much about his literacy understandings and practices. He understands the interactional and relational functions of writing; he writes for a communicative purpose. Nico wanted to deliver a message to his teacher, to communicate with her. He employed approximations, used upper- and lowercase letters to make meaning, and his meaning was clear. Familiar with the genre of birthday cards, he used big letters on a page to wish her happy birthday. Then, he declared that she was the best teacher. His exclamation mark makes such declaration clear. He wrote

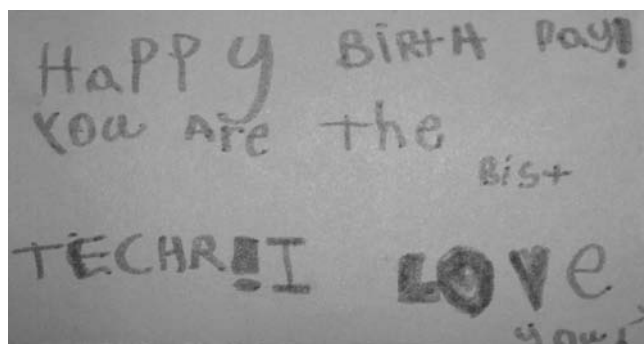


FIGURE 3.6 Happy Birth Day! You Are The Bist Techr! I LOVE You!

LOVE in bold capital letters, making a smiley face out of the letter O and a heart out of the letter V. The paper, pencil, and letters (symbols) were deployed by Nico to convey a very particular meaning, being used as specific mediating devices (Wertsch 1998) to get in synch with his teacher, to communicate. Specifically, he was trying to establish an affective connection with his teacher, making a birthday card as a way to engage in a private interaction with his teacher, within a context in which collective communication is the norm. He engaged with literacy as a social practice, actively and purposefully. His literacy learning was palpable as his participation in his classroom community changed (Rogoff 2003). But to realize the power and potential of Nico's literacy practice, we must not only move beyond reductive theories, but also beyond reductive applications of theories, what Rose (1988) calls "cognitive reductionism."

For example, not to engage in cognitive reductionism of young children's cultural processes, we must recognize that their "participation in the practices of dynamic cultural communities can be distinguished from membership in ethnic groups, which often is treated in an all-or-none, static fashion" (Gutiérrez and Rogoff 2003, 21). After all, as Cole and Engeström (1993, 15) argue, culture "is experienced in local, face-to-face interactions that are locally constrained and heterogeneous with respect to both 'culture as a whole' and the parts of the entire toolkit experienced by any given individual."

The way that children negotiate meaning, becoming literate beings and being "symbol makers, symbol weavers" (Dyson 1990), is one of the most impressive achievements of humanity. Because children are cultural beings, literacies develop differently, based on social, cultural, historical, and political processes and interactions in different classrooms, (pre)schools, communities, and societies. Young children learn and grow within the context of cultural communities, "coordinated group[s] of people with some traditions and understandings in common, extending across several generations, with varied roles and practices and continual change among participants as well as transformation in the community's practices" (Gutiérrez and Rogoff 2003, 21). Individually and collectively, they develop the capacity to link play, interactions, pictures, and print in sophisticated ways. Reflecting on what this means with regard to the example presented earlier, we can see that Nico took on an agentive role, coordinating tools (deploying paper and marker to write), and authoring symbols, to engage in communication with his teacher.

Social Contexts of Children's Literacy Practices

Gordon Wells (1986) writes about multiple social contexts and underscores that social contexts extend beyond the contexts where literacy practices occur. There are multiple social contexts within schools, homes, and communities. It is in such contexts that children learn how to make meaning—through spoken utterances, written words, and gestures. A child's individual literacy practices are deeply influenced by the context(s) in which they take place. So, to understand early literacy,

we must consider individual practices as well as societal practices. As we enter Phillip's Head Start classroom, we learn from Tamikka and Brianna about the social contexts shaping their literacy practices and enactments.

Three-year-old Tamikka and four-year-old Brianna created imaginary worlds in a pretend grocery store (Figure 3.7). Brianna played the mother. Tamikka played the daughter. As they were in the middle of grocery shopping, shopping list in hand (comprised of symbols such as scribbles and drawings), Tamikka answered the telephone with a smile and a pleasant voice: "Hey guuurl, how you doin'?" After a few seconds, she continued, "I know that's right. I know that's right," as she laughed with gusto. As she put a plastic vegetable in her basket, Brianna tugged on her shirt, saying "Moouooooomaaaa" loudly. Tamikka's demeanor immediately changed as she firmly looked at Brianna (embodying the behavior culturally known as "giving her the look"), pointed to a chair, and said: "You hush, chile." She crossed off an item Brianna had added to the list. Brianna made a sad face and looked down. Within the space of seconds, Tamikka's communicative practices and roles shifted—all within the same physical context, but in shifting interactional terrains and social contexts. Tamikka's linguistic registers¹—or "social languages" as Gee (1996, 2002) proposes—shifted.

Tamikka's performance helps us understand that language use is not generic. It is specific and situated. Gee (2002, 31) proposes: "Social languages are varieties of a language that are associated with specific socially situated identities ('who is talking/writing/acting') and specific socially-situated activities ('what is being done')." In the scenario above, Tamikka embodied two distinct socially situated identities—as someone's *sista* and as Brianna's *momma*. Although both social languages in use are employed within the context of pretend (through play), Tamikka displayed awareness of social language in use related to specific socially situated activities. Social languages both reflect and construct the identities Tamikka enacted during each of the particular times and particular interactions—even though she remained in the same physical space. Tamikka drew on grammatical resources differently in each of the interactions described earlier. Such social languages and the grammatical elements deployed are relevant not only for oral but for written language as well.

This ability to organize and express inner feelings and experiences through shared gestural, visual, and verbal symbols is a part of children's human heritage; meaning making, like eating and sleeping, is an inherent part of being alive. (Dyson 1990, 50–51)

As we frame children as capable literate beings, we come to see that Tamikka and Brianna's shopping list is "no longer seen as evidence of children's immature understanding of the world . . . Rather, they are viewed as evidence of children's creative capacity for discerning links between a symbolic meaning . . . and some thing" (Dyson 1990, 51). It's easy to see how play has a key role in children's growth and development as symbol makers and symbol weavers.



FIGURE 3.7 Negotiating Literacies Across Interactional Contexts

Play is a space where they can take risks and engage with a broad variety of symbols authentically.

It is within a variety of social contexts that children learn language and negotiate literacies through their use. Before entering (pre)school, they may have developed literacy as defined by traditional benchmarks, such as accuracy, fluency, and comprehension, as they read a variety of symbols and communicate. Through authentic interactions, they negotiate literate identities, communicating meanings across contexts. Literacies emanate from the “dynamic relationship between individual and collective practices and sociohistorical change” (Brandt 2001, 201). Often, we adults are the ones who do not see how children already have such skills and practices. We position ourselves as “sponsors” of literacy; that is, we “provide, enhance, or deny opportunities for literacy learning” (Brandt 2001, 203). Brandt (2001, 201) underscores: “In an information economy, reading and writing serve as both instruments and products by which surplus wealth gets produced and competitive advantages get won.” Literacy becomes quantified as an economic tool. From such a perspective, instead of learning about children’s literacies, we adults are often too quick to judge children’s literacy practices against our own individual (often restrictive) definitions of literacy: reading books and writing words.

Literacy learning happens in the context of classrooms and communities, where students’ “linguistic and cultural-historical repertoires” (Gutiérrez and Rogoff 2003, 22) can be positioned as curricular resources. After all, children learn through participation in communities of practice (Rogoff 2003). Regrettably, young children who have been socialized into literacy practices that do not have power in schools (as book reading and writing letters do) tend to be disadvantaged. Those whose home communicative practices align with the interactional norms of schools are advantaged; their home communicative practices are valued—not

necessarily because they have more complex syntax, but because they meet what is expected in and by schools. That is, “[a] person’s unconscious knowledge of both linguistic and social rules . . . enable her to use language appropriately in different social contexts. When a speaker applies these rules in talking or interacting, she is engaged in communicative performance” (Genishi and Dyson 1984, 5). This is illustrated by Souto-Manning’s (2013) study that looked closely at language misalignment, academic achievement, and participation in affinity groups (in this study, those children with knowledge of and interest in *Bakugan* and *Little Pet Shop*), which can be defined as communities of individuals with a shared affinity-identity (Gee 2001). In this case, the closer a child’s language was to the dominant language used in schooling, the more likely the child was to be seen as competent by his/her teachers and peers—socially and academically.

The Sociocultural Nature of Early Literacy

As we reenter Phillip’s Head Start classroom, we see how cultural practices get reenacted day in and day out. For example, one day, in the housekeeping area, Tiffany pretended to be a baby doll’s momma, reading *The Three Bears* to the baby (Figure 3.8). She was clearly familiar with the behaviors associated with reading. She knew that print carried a message as she swooped her right thumb underneath the words printed in the book. She knew that books carried messages—or told stories—and was familiar with the concept of audience. Even though the book she was reading was titled *Colors* and not *The Three Bears* as she had announced, she displayed many emergent reading behaviors. Where had she learned them? “From my grandmomma,” she responded, explaining that when they go to church her grandmother swoops her finger under the words in the Bible. She also shared that her grandmother read to put her baby sibling to sleep. Yet, her grandmother was not formally literate (could not read and write in the traditional sense, decoding and encoding words)—she was engaging in reading behaviors, on the discourse of storybook reading. Gee (2002) proposes that literacy is a socioculturally situated practice. As Tiffany was socialized into book reading through her interactions with her grandmother, she acquired other cultural models—about reading and about the world (such as women being primary caregivers for babies).

Tiffany also displayed her awareness of social language and literacy practices (Gee 2002), displaying her knowledge of different genres as she switched between reading the book and talking to the baby doll. She engaged in greeting rituals, which tend to be more fixed and predictable, asking the baby, “You okay?” and “You liking the story, huh?” She also engaged in storybook reading, introducing the book to the baby doll, looking at the cover of the book, telling the title, reading the story, offering a closing event, and then commenting on it. This is a practice her grandmother had engaged in, modeling it again and again. While she



FIGURE 3.8 Enacting Concepts about Print

pretended to decode words, her knowledge of a child's storybook structure was sophisticated as displayed by the structure employed in her reading of the book.

As we seek to understand the implications of social languages and genres (as evident in the scenarios featuring Tamikka, Brianna, and Tiffany), it is important to understand that “social languages and genres are not a product of a human biological capacity; rather, they are creatures of history and culture” (Gee 2002, 35). This understanding urges us to reconsider the traditional definition of early literacy as learning to read. It begs us to challenge it, seeking to understand the brilliance of young children as they negotiate a variety of social practices, social languages, and genres—within and across (pre)school, home, and communities. Early literacy thus encompasses blazing multiple pathways to and with words—oral or written—alongside lots more!

But, how are social languages and genres (such as those displayed by Tamikka, Brianna, and Tiffany) acquired? According to Gee (2002, 35), “through processes of socialization. . . . When people learn new social languages and genres—at the level of being able to produce them and not just consume them—they are being socialized into . . . Discourses with a big ‘D.’”

Discourses as the Production of Social Languages and Literate Identities

Discourses with a big D involve more than language. “Social languages are embedded within Discourses and only have relevance and meaning within them” (Gee 2002, 35). So, Tamikka, Brianna, and Tiffany could perform specific social languages because they were fluent in the Discourses associated with talking with a

close friend, disciplining a child, and reading a storybook. “A Discourse integrates ways of talking, listening, writing, reading, acting, interacting, believing, valuing, and feeling (using various objects, symbols, images, tools and technologies) in the service of enacting meaningful socially situated identities and activities” (Gee 2002, 35). Gee (1996, 2002) invites us to consider Discourses as identity kits, which allow individuals to enact specific identities and engage in activities related to that identity. As they are socialized into particular Discourses, individuals acquire “cultural models” (Holland, Lachicotte, Skinner, and Cain 2001) or theories about the world (Gee 2002). Such cultural models define what counts as “normal” and “typical” in classrooms and in society.

Cultural models also shape larger professional practices and guidelines in exclusive and situated ways, such as the case of the Developmentally Appropriate Practice guide in early childhood education (Copple and Bredekamp 2009). Cultural models are situated and informed by particular perspectives and points of view. They are not right or wrong as absolute constructs. Cultural models influence our ideas of the world in general and of early literacy in particular. As such, notions of what is deemed to be “appropriate” and/or “best” in early childhood education must be acknowledged within a context in which ethnocentrism reigns. That is, it is important to acknowledge and question what counts as best and appropriate. After all, as New and Mallory (1994) posited, the word *appropriate* is inherently cultural. Thus, such notions must be troubled as they are ethnocentric constructs (Souto-Manning 2010a), ideas and concepts based on the understanding and belief that one’s own group or culture is better or more important than others and should serve as the standard against which all other practices are rated.

Literacy as Reading and Writing the World, as a Political Endeavor

Freire (1970) proposes that education is inherently political, and so is literacy. “It should serve as a starting point and not an end in itself” (Souto-Manning 2010b, 8). Literacy is at once historical, theoretical, social, and political. But it often gets stripped of such components, becoming a tool for colonization and (at times) an insurmountable obstacle to access. “Reading does not consist merely of decoding the written word or language; rather, it is preceded by and intertwined with knowledge of the world. Language and reality are dynamically interconnected” (Freire and Macedo 1998, 8).

Literacy is realized as human beings read worlds and words—and author them. Thus, literacy is not merely depositing literacy strategies and tools into students’ brains (via the banking concept of education), but a critical co-construction of the world. The banking concept of education disempowers and colonizes. As Freire (2000) explains, “[t]he dominant elites utilize the banking concept to encourage passivity in the oppressed, corresponding with

the latter's 'submerged' state of consciousness, and take advantage of that passivity to 'fill' that consciousness with slogans which create even more fear of freedom" (p. 95). This is simply not how teaching and learning (complex processes) happen.

The pedagogy of literacy is also political—whether it is by sanctioning texts for read alouds that fail to serve as mirrors for children from minoritized backgrounds (Bishop 1990), by covertly deeming one register to be correct (the dominant language of/in schooling), or by engaging in teaching actions and interactions that honor some families' ways of communicating while invisibilizing others. "Many political and educational plans have failed because their authors designed them according to their own personal views of reality, never once taking into account . . . [those for] whom their program was ostensibly directed" (Freire 1996, 75). Even pedagogical practices such as picture reading, which some posit emanated from show ways (quilts used by formerly enslaved Africans migrating North) were appropriated without credit, claimed by Whiteified practices (see Woodson, 2005). Additionally, interactional patterns commonly employed in classrooms reflect socialization in a particular Discourse (Gee 1996). Thus, teaching, learning, literacy, and curriculum are inherently political.

As children who are members of minoritized communities navigate within and across multiple communicative practices within and across contexts, they are often taught that their language is wrong and needs to be fixed. Also, the communicative competence that children display by moving back and forth between dialects, vernaculars, and registers gets ignored in monolingual classrooms. For example, words such as *parkeastes*, which employ Spanish-language verb conjugation conventions to English verbs (e.g., park) in sophisticated ways are too often seen as deficits, as signaling lack of knowledge, instead of according to the resourcefulness and creativity employed.

With regard to talk (classroom discourse), Cazden (2001) documents how IRE (initiation-response-evaluation) is commonly used in classrooms, labeling it "the language of teaching and learning." She explained: "Patterns of language use affect what counts as 'knowledge,' and what occurs as learning" and asked: "How do these patterns affect the equality, or inequality, or students' educational opportunities?" (p. 3). The answer is: in multiple ways! Dyson and Smitherman (2009) explain how "sounding right" in the classroom is based on the assumption that dominant American English and its communicative patterns are what count as right. Regarding AAL, Dyson and Smitherman (2009, 973) explain that it:

[H]as a rich history of scholarship that both documents its historical evolution and sociolinguistic complexity and reveals the persistent lack of knowledge about AAL in our schools and the continuing negative stereotypes about its speakers. Currently, federal funds for early schooling target the literacy learning of low-income children, who are disproportionately children of

color; these programs, though, assume, as a literacy “basic,” a singular correct way of using language.

Within such a context, there are misalignments and disconnects between students’ practices and the aims and goals of schools and schooling. They go on to explain that sounding

“[R]ight” to young children will vary for developmental, situational, and, as emphasized herein, sociocultural reasons . . . [and] illustrate how, in the course of teacher-student interaction, young children’s major resources for learning to write—their very voices—may become a source of problems. (Dyson and Smitherman 2009, 973)

Educators often frame these as problems of the individual, under the guise of readiness and remediation. Here, we engage with the notion of *re-mediation* (Gutiérrez et al. 2009) as we see a need for reorganizing classroom spaces, curriculum, and resources in ways that honor and build on children’s languages and literacies as assets.

Differences in communicative patterns can have dire consequences for young children. For example, a U.S. kindergartner, George, had been sent to detention more than half of his school days due to his use of AAL (Souto-Manning 2009a). His communicative practice was read by his teacher as problematic, signaling a behavior problem. For example, his White middle-class kindergarten teacher, thinking that she was being polite, would use “George, would you like to . . .?” preceding a direction (such as “Sit down.”). George understood such indirect clauses cloaked as questions to truly signal a question for him to consider and answer. His teacher used questions and indirectness as markers of politeness. Because she was in a position of power, her communicative practices held more weight; she ethnocentrically scaled and rated George’s communication against hers. So, instead of learning about his home communicative practices, she deemed them wrong and denied George access to learning. As with George, many children are not socialized in dominant American English patterns prior to entering schooling. In fact, young children may feel that it is silly to respond to questions that the teacher already has the answer to—not seeing the function of this type of communication. This disadvantages them.

Literacy “provides a referent . . . to further interrogate and reflect upon questions” (Giroux 1987, 6). In reading and critically rereading realities, one can engage in the counter-hegemonic act (Gramsci 1971) of rewriting what was read, authoring more hopeful and just tomorrows. Bartolomé (1996, 235) proposes that through literacy, teachers “can either maintain the status quo, or they can work to transform the sociocultural reality at the classroom and school level so that the culture at this micro-level does not reflect macro-level inequalities.” Here, we introduce three ways of transforming unjust sociocultural realities: embodied literacy, racial literacy, and critical literacy. We do so as we seek to challenge the idea that reading is simply calling out words (Freire 1985a).

Embodied Literacy

Play is an embodied literacy (see Chapter 2): “Its multimodal facility for manipulating meanings and contexts powerfully shapes children’s learning and participation in classrooms” (Wohlwend 2008, 128). Going beyond printed symbols and serving purposes external to communication, play allows teachers to see children as fully capable and to expand our conception of communicative repertoires and of literacy itself.

Heath (1982, 93) defines literacy events as “any occasion in which a piece of writing is integral to the nature of the participants’ interactions and their interpretive processes.” Here, we recognize that while writing is a particular enactment of literacy, it is not the only one, and we call for a more inclusive and child-centric definition of what counts as a literacy event to be any event where meaning is negotiated in a social context. We draw on Moje’s (2000, 655) definition of literacy practices as “socially situated beliefs, values, and purposes that shape how and why people use literacy” and on Thiel’s (2015, 46) call for us to acknowledge that:

Literacy is not bound in manuscripts, coiled up in composition notebooks, and encased in mark making utensils, nor is literacy merely a communication tool. Literacies are leaky, seeping deep into our bodies and unfurled through our movements, perceptions, and reactions to other bodies.

While storybook reading and bedtime stories are literacy events, so is play. In play, children bring together multiple meanings, embodying semiotic signs and signifying in multiple ways. Wohlwend (2008, 128) posits that “Children emphasize or combine particular modes to strategically amplify their intended meanings as they play: (1) to try out social practices, (2) to explore the multimodal potential of material resources, and (3) to construct spaces for peer culture within classrooms.” Through play, children negotiate their membership in specific communities, take up a number of (real and imagined) identities, and have opportunities to perform literate identities and make sense of texts (Wohlwend 2007, 2008). Through play, children create affinity groups around shared interests as “activities or routines, artifacts, values, and concerns that children produce and share in interaction with peers” (Corsaro and Eder 1990, 197).

This is political because once a common staple in early education (Paley 1992), play has been pushed out of early childhood classrooms in the name of academic standards, in favor of teachers imparting knowledge and strategies and enacting a banking approach to education. Making room for play (especially the child-led messy play which offers so many spaces for learning) has become a revolutionary act (Souto-Manning 2017). Further, conceptualizing play as an embodied literacy is a political stance. After all, it involves rereading our own conceptualizations of literacy, often restrictive and adult-centric to understand the ways in which children creatively author through the creative use of materials (Kress 2003).

In Phillip’s Head Start classroom, children engaged in multimodal authoring through embodied literacies as meaning makers—using objects, gestures, sounds, images, and more. Within the context of this Head Start classroom, play was reconceptualized because “multimodal literacy re-centers play in school curriculum as a valuable semiotic system in its own right and revalues play as essential to ‘new basics’” (Wohlwend 2008, 135). Three-, four-, and five-year-old children authored stories, resignedified objects and signs, and engaged in flexible and creative meaning making. They expressed their ideas and employed authentic communication. For example, it was not uncommon for children to undertake authoring stories by repurposing cloth and other materials (as shown in Figure 3.9). They transformed the carpet into a bed, for example, as they enacted specific roles and an intricate storyline. As Wohlwend and Hall (2016, 155) explain, “Young children’s



FIGURE 3.9 Embodied Literacy

engagements with literacy occur as immersive and embodied interactions,” filled with “emotional investments” (p. 166). When we recognize embodied literacies, we also “recognize children as knowledgeable cultural participants and creative cultural producers” (p. 167).

Yet, as adults, we are often (even if unknowingly) “bound by cultural convention, correctness of form, and ready-made signs of written language, [whereas] children are freer to invent their own signs with whatever materials, modes, and semiotic systems (including play) are suited to the immediate purpose” (Wohlwend 2008, 128). Cultural conventions can stifle young children’s learning processes as we often hold these conventions as norms against which to rate children’s creative engagements. As we recognize the political nature of literacy—what is present, absent, which stories are told, whose communicative practices are included or excluded—we must move toward revisioning what counts as early literacy. We take up the task of expanding literacies, honoring embodiment and emotionality, exploring it further in Chapter 6: Languages and Literacies in Peer Culture, reconceptualizing childhood cultures as spaces for children’s construction of language and literacy repertoires (Corsaro 2003; Paley 1992; Wohlwend 2011; Yoon 2014).

Racial Literacy

What does literacy have to do with race? And why identify “racial literacy?” This is a question considered by Guinier (2003, 2004), who calls for educators and educational researchers to move from racial liberalism to racial literacy, proposing, “In order to change the way race is understood, race has to be directly addressed rather than ignored” (Guinier 2003, 207). Guinier (2004, 114) invites us to “rethink race as an instrument of social, geographic and economic control” and proposes that “racial literacy offers a more dynamic framework for understanding American racism.” According to Guinier (2004, 202), a racially literate person uses “race as a diagnostic device, an analytic tool, and an instrument of process.” Employing Guinier’s framework in an early childhood setting, Rogers and Mosley (2006, 465) succinctly explain:

First, racial literacy defines racism as a structural problem rather than as an individual one. Second, racial literacy locates debates about public process, which are often cloaked in the subtext of race, within an explicitly democratic context that is forward looking. Third, the process dimension to racial literacy can be used to guide participatory problem solving.

In Phillip’s Head Start classroom, racial literacy allowed young children to refute internalized racism as displayed by their loved ones. For example, Rashon (Figure 3.10) dreamed of having dreadlocks. His father communicated that he

thought dreadlocks had a negative connotation. Discussing how others see students and how students see themselves through racialized lenses and honoring children's conflicts and questions, Phillip engaged the class in a discussion of who is bad and why, unveiling the racialization of "being bad," even by children of color.

The construction of who is good and who is bad had previously and problematically been "cloaked in the subtext of race" (Rogers and Mosley 2006, 465). Then, Phillip asked, "Do you really believe this?" and "Why?" They worked to uncover why their image of "being bad" was racialized. They shared their personal experiences. They talked about loved ones. Together, they understood the association of dreadlocks with "being bad" as a structural idea, and not as an individual belief. Phillip guided the class in participatory problem solving, problematizing racial texts and subtexts. Through such a process, Rashon then felt comfortable resignifying a shirt from the housekeeping area of the classroom as his "thinking dreads," which signaled that he was ready to work (see Figure 3.10). Dreadlocks were resignified from "being bad" to "being ready to think," begging us to trouble traditional constructs and notions—such as readiness.



FIGURE 3.10 Performing Counterstories, Authoring Selves

Critical Literacy

Critical literacy practices originated from critical pedagogy, bringing to life the many sociocultural, historical, and political meanings behind texts and contexts (Comber 2003, Vasquez 2014). Critical pedagogy premises that individual human beings are agents of change, linking critical theory and classroom practices (Freire 1970). Through critical pedagogy, teachers transform their classrooms into spaces where students can engage in critical conversations and take action around issues of power, privilege, literacy, diversity, and social action. According to McLaren (1999, 50),

[A] pedagogy of critical literacy becomes the primary vehicle for the development of “critical consciousness”. . . . Literacy . . . becomes that common “process” of participation open to all individuals. The problem of “critical consciousness” cannot be posed in abstraction from the significant historical contexts in which knowledge is produced, engaged, and appropriated.

Critical literacy practices come to life through everyday classroom practices in unique ways within and across contexts and “involve people using language to exercise power, to enhance everyday life in schools and communities, and to question practices of privilege and injustice” (Comber 2001b, 1). Underlying critical literacy frameworks is Freire and Macedo’s (1987, viii) notion that critical literacy is about “reading the word, and the world” and seeing the world from particular frames. A central aim of critical literacy is to “use texts as social tools in ways that allow for a reconstruction of these same worlds” (Luke 2000, 453). This framework draws attention to what is included in and what is left out of a text and pushes us to identify the ideological underpinnings of texts (Luke 2000).

In Phillip’s Head Start classroom, critical literacies were negotiated day in and day out, as children read injustices in their classroom and in the world and sought to promote change. At times, they brought such issues into classroom community meetings, other times students addressed issues through writing (e.g., writing letters, seeking to promote change, and fostering more just practices). There were many critical literacy actions taken up by Phillip’s students as they sought to transform their worlds.

Literacies in Multiple Social Worlds: Understanding Social Literacy Practices

In this chapter, we examined how literacy is practiced in nuanced ways across different cultural communities. Through a number of examples, we made visible how young children navigated multiple social worlds (Gutiérrez 2008) organized by sets of rules, interactions, and social practices, which can be challenged and changed (Vasquez 2014). After all,

[O]nly when we understand a child's multiple literacies (i.e., different ways with words embedded in different social practices and Discourses) in a . . . specific and situated way . . . can we really understand and appropriately assess a child's language and literacy development. This most certainly means understanding children's specific "ways with words" that, while rooted in home or community-based Discourses, are not "school aligned" (and, in fact, children from all cultural groups have these, though some have more than others). It means, as well, questioning the rather general way in which literacy is treated in school, much academic research, and in assessing children. (Gee 2002, 41)

In Part II (Chapters 4, 5, and 6), we seek to understand relational literacies, "practices through which we learn to exist differently and simultaneously" (Martin 2013, 137), sites of production of third spaces, enacted with the people who are present in young children's lives and anchored in the spaces young children belong. In doing so, we delve into literacies in families and homes (Chapter 4), in neighborhoods and communities (Chapter 5), and within the context of peers and peer culture (Chapter 6).

Note

1. According to Schiffman and Spooner (2012), a linguistic register refers to: "A set of specialized vocabulary and preferred (or dispreferred) syntactic and rhetorical devices/structures, used by specific socio-professional groups for special purposes" (p. 22).